

Europe Isn't Quite San Fran

San Francisco's mayor had declared a few months ago that Wi-Fi was a fundamental human right. In contrast, the EU recently announced that the universal service obligation, which currently covers landline telecoms, won't be extended to cover broadband and mobile services



Your Laptop Or Your Life!

Just a week after it was announced that plans for free wireless broadband for San Francisco residents were finalised, laptop thefts at wireless cafes rose. Coffee-houses, restaurants, and digital cafes—once digital sanctuaries—are now a hunting ground for thieves



Escape

COULD-DO-WITHOUT RESEARCH

What's He Doing Up There?

If you've ever been to a classical concert—or watched one on TV—you've probably wondered what the conductor is doing, prancing about the stage and waving his arms. Now, a research project is aiming to find out what reactions a conductor's actions translate into—in the musicians, and in the audience. Conductor Keith Lockhart, five Boston Symphony Orchestra musicians, and some audience members were involved in the experiment in mid-April, at a concert featuring the overture to *The Marriage of Figaro*. Lockhart was wired up with sensors that measured his heart rate, muscle tension, and so on. Five musicians were wired to measure how they reacted to Lockhart's conducting. Some members of the audience wore sensors so the scientists could tell



Illustrations: Harsho Mohan Chatteraj

what kinds of emotional intensity they were feeling.

Teresa Nakra, a former MIT doctoral student, was one of those involved in the experiment. She said similar experiments in the past had shown that conductors' gestures are

based on their emotions.

Huh? Couldn't we have figured that out without elaborate experiments involving sensors?

"I think a lot of people wonder what the conductor accomplishes standing up there," Nakra said. The sensors are worth \$80,000, and Nakra and her colleagues said they were expecting to answer that question.

Again, huh? If people are wondering, why not ask the conductor and the musicians what's going on up there?

We're seeing more and more such useless research these days—if the tech is there, use it somewhere! What's next? Research to see

Whatever Happened To...

VRML?

Interactive 3D on the Web? Imagine being able to take a virtual tour of your renovated house *before* the actual renovation; being able to move stuff around willy-nilly on the slightest whim. What if you could check out merchandise from all possible angles in a virtual shopping mall?

All these wondrous abilities, and many more, were promised to us via VRML—the Virtual Reality Markup Language—which became a buzzword in the first crazy days of the World Wide Web. So why aren't we roaming virtual malls and throwing virtual vases around?

VRML went flat for two reasons: the first is the VRML browser wars—different browsers expected VRML to be written in their own special way, so compatibility was almost non-existent. Secondly, hardware wasn't ready for ubiquitous 3D just yet, so having it on the Web wasn't going to achieve much anyway.

But VRML isn't dead yet—the Web3D consortium is giving it a new avatar—the X3D specification, which also makes use of browsers' XML Parsers to create 3D objects on the web. It's still in its infancy, but is rising quite strongly. It's a standard, so we won't witness any new browser wars—and with OpenGL being supported on nearly all modern PCs, hardware isn't an issue anymore, either.

Right now, X3D is being used for CAD and educational purposes, and will hopefully make its way soon into more applications we can all enjoy.

Win! My Desktop Contest

This month's winner is **Debangshu Sen** from West Bengal. Here's what he used:

- ☐ Chameleon Clock 3.5 for the floating clock
- ☐ IconPackager 3.1 for the desktop icons
- ☐ DesktopX 3.10 for the Email Object
- ☐ Sun & Moon on Screen v1.0
- ☐ Start Killer 2.3 to remove the start button
- ☐ Hide Window Now v2.5 to hide the system clock, icons and taskbar notification area
- ☐ AlphaXP 1.1.2 to make the taskbar transparent



Send your desktop with an exact description of how you made it to mydesktop@thinkdigit.com with the subject 'My Desktop' and tell us your postal address, too.